

VAR ASSISTANT REFEREE (VAR) PROTOCOL



1. Principles

The VAR protocol, as far as possible, conforms to the principles and philosophy of the Laws of the Game.

Handbook, and has received written permission from FIFA.

Principles

The use of VARs in football matches is based on a number of principles, all of which must apply in every match using VARs (except for incorrectly awarded corner kicks – see point e. under '2. Reviewable decisions/incidents').



1. A video assistant referee (VAR) is a match official, with independent access to match footage, who may assist the referee only in the event of a **'clear and obvious error'** or **'serious missed incident'** in relation to:

a. Goal/no goal

b. Penalty/no penalty

c. Red card (including a clearly incorrect second caution)

d. Mistaken identity (when the referee cautions or sends off the wrong player)

2. The referee must always make a decision, i.e. the referee is not permitted to give 'no decision' and then use the VAR to make the decision; a decision to allow play to continue after an alleged offence can be reviewed.

4. Only the referee can initiate a 'review'; the VAR (and other match officials) can only recommend a 'review' to the referee.
5. The final decision is always taken by the referee, either based on information from the VAR or after the referee has undertaken an 'on-field review' (OFR).
6. There is no time limit for the review process as accuracy is more important than speed.
7. The players and team officials must not surround the referee or attempt to influence if a decision is reviewed, the review process or the final decision.
8. The referee must remain 'visible' during the review process to ensure transparency.
9. If play continues after an incident which is then reviewed, any disciplinary action taken/required during the post-incident period is not cancelled, even if the original decision is changed (except a caution/sending-off for stopping or interfering with a promising attack or DOGSO).
10. If play has stopped and been restarted, the referee may not undertake a 'review' except for a case of mistaken identity or for a potential sending-off offence relating to violent conduct, spitting, biting or extremely offensive, insulting and/or abusive action(s).



12. As the VAR will automatically 'check' every situation/decision, there is no need for coaches or players to request a 'review'.





2. Reviewable decisions/incidents

The referee may receive assistance from the VAR only in relation to five categories of decisions/incidents. In all these situations, the VAR is only used after the referee has made a (first/original) decision (including allowing play to continue), or if a serious incident is missed/not seen by the match officials.

The referee`s original decision will not be changed unless there was a 'clear and obvious error' (this includes any decision made by the referee based on information from another match official e.g. offside).

a. Goal/no goal

attacking team offence in the build-up to or scoring of the goal (handball, foul, offside etc.)

ball out of play prior to the goal

goal/no goal decisions

offence by goalkeeper and/or kicker at the taking of a penalty kick or encroachment by an attacker or defender who becomes directly involved in play if the penalty kick rebounds from the goalpost, crossbar or goalkeeper



b. Penalty kick/no penalty kick

attacking team offence in the build-up to the penalty incident (handball, foul, offside etc.)

ball out of play prior to the incident

location of offence (inside or outside the penalty area)

penalty kick incorrectly awarded

penalty kick offence not penalised

c. Red cards

DOGSO (especially position of offence and positions of other players)

using offensive, insulting or abusive action(s)

clearly incorrect second caution

d. Mistaken identity (red or yellow card)

If the referee penalises an offence but has clearly misidentified the player who committed that offence, only the identity of the offender can be reviewed.



e. Clearly incorrectly awarded corner kick if the decision can be changed immediately and without delaying the restart (competition option)

3. Practicalities

The use of VARs during a match involves the following practical arrangements:

The VAR watches the match in the video operation room (VOR) assisted by one or more assistant VARs (AVARs)

Depending on the number of camera angles and other considerations, there may be more than one AVAR and one or more replay operators (ROs)

Only authorised persons are allowed to enter the VOR or communicate with the VAR/AVAR/RO during the match

and can hear everything they say; the VAR can only speak to the referee by pushing a button (to avoid the referee being distracted by conversations in the VOR)

If the VAR is busy with a 'check' or a 'review', the AVAR may speak to the referee especially if the game needs to be stopped or to ensure play does not restart

If the referee decides to view the replay footage, the VAR will select the best angle/replay speed; the referee can request other/additional angles/speeds



4. Procedures

Original decision

The referee and other match officials must always make an initial decision (including any disciplinary action) as if there was no VAR (except for a 'missed' incident)

The referee and other match officials are not permitted to give 'no decision' as this will lead to 'weak/indecisive' officiating, too many 'reviews' and significant problems if there is a technology failure

The referee is the only person who can make the final decision; the VAR has the same status as the other match officials and can only assist the referee

Delaying the flag/whistle for an offence is only permissible in *a very clear attacking situation* when a player is about to score a goal or has a clear run into/towards the opponents' penalty area

or throw-in, or retains possession of the ball after the initial attack has ended; in all other situations, the assistant referee should decide whether or not to raise the flag, depending on the requirements of the game

Check

The VAR automatically 'checks' the TV camera footage for every potential or actual goal, penalty or direct red card decision/incident, or a case of mistaken identity, using different camera angles and replay speeds

The VAR can 'check' the footage in normal speed and/or in slow motion but, in general, slow motion replays should only be used for facts, e.g. position of offence/player, point of contact for physical offences and handball, ball out of play (including goal/no goal); normal speed should be used for the 'intensity' of an offence or to decide if it was a handball offence

If the 'check' does not indicate a 'clear and obvious error' or 'serious missed incident', there is usually no need for the VAR to communicate with the referee – this is a 'silent check'; however, it sometimes helps the referee/assistant referee to manage the players/match if the VAR confirms that no 'clear and obvious error' or 'serious missed incident' occurred

If the restart of play needs to be delayed for a 'check', the referee will signal this by clearly holding a finger to the earpiece/headset and extending the other hand/arm; this



If the 'check' indicates a probable 'clear and obvious error' or 'serious missed incident', the VAR will communicate this information to the referee, who will then decide whether or not to initiate a 'review'

Review

The referee can initiate a 'review' for a potential 'clear and obvious error' or 'serious missed incident' when:

- the VAR (or another match official) recommends a 'review'
- the referee suspects that something serious has been 'missed'

If play has already stopped, the referee delays the restart

If play has not already stopped, the referee stops play when the ball is next in a neutral zone/situation (usually when neither team is in an attacking move) and shows the 'TV signal'

The VAR describes to the referee what can be seen on the TV replay(s) and the referee then:

- shows the 'TV signal' (if not already shown) and goes to the referee review area to view replay footage – 'on-field review' (OFR) – before making a final decision. The other match officials will not review the footage unless, in exceptional circumstances, asked to do so by the referee

or



review'

At the end of both review processes, the referee must show the 'TV signal' immediately followed by the final decision

For subjective decisions, e.g. intensity of a foul challenge, interference at offside, handball considerations, an 'on-field review' (OFR) is appropriate

For factual decisions e.g. position of an offence or player (offside), point of contact (handball/foul), location (inside or outside the penalty area), ball out of play etc. a 'VAR-only review' is usually appropriate but an 'on-field review' (OFR) can be used for a factual decision if it will help manage the players/match or 'sell' the decision (e.g. a crucial match-deciding decision late in the game)

The referee can request different cameras angles/replay speeds but, in general, slow motion replays should only be used for facts, e.g. position of offence/player, point of contact for physical offences and handball, ball out of play (including goal/no goal); normal speed should be used for the 'intensity' of an offence or to decide if it was a handball offence

For decisions/incidents relating to goals, penalty/no penalty and red cards for denying an obvious goal-scoring opportunity (DOGSO), it may be necessary to review the attacking phase of play which led directly to the decision/incident; this may include how the attacking team gained possession of the ball in open play

The Laws of the Game do not allow restart decisions (corner kicks, throw-ins etc.) to be changed once play has restarted, so they cannot be reviewed



sending-off offence relating to violent conduct, spitting, biting or extremely offensive, insulting and/or abusive action(s)

The review process should be completed as efficiently as possible, but the accuracy of the final decision is more important than speed. For this reason, and because some situations are complex with several reviewable decisions/incidents, there is no maximum time limit for the review process



Final decision

When the review process is completed, the referee must show the 'TV signal' and communicate the final decision; competitions may also implement a system in which the referee publicly explains and announces decisions following a VAR 'review' or lengthy VAR 'check', as outlined in the FIFA guidelines and the VAR Handbook
The referee will then take/change/rescind any disciplinary action (where appropriate) and restart play in accordance with the Laws of the Game

Players, substitutes and team officials

As the VAR will automatically 'check' every situation/incident, there is no need for coaches or players to request a '**check**' or '**review**'

Players, substitutes and team officials must not attempt to influence or interfere with the review process, including when the final decision is communicated

A player/substitute/substituted player/team official who excessively shows the 'TV signal' or enters the RRA will be cautioned

A player/substitute/substituted player/team official who enters the VOR will be sent off

Match validity

In principle, a match is not invalidated because of:

malfunction(s) of the VAR technology (as for goal line technology (GLT))

wrong decision(s) involving the VAR (as the VAR is a match official)

decision(s) not to review an incident

review(s) of a non-reviewable situation/decision



Incapacitated VAR, AVAR or replay operator

Law 6 – The Other Match Officials stipulates: 'Competition rules must state clearly who replaces a match official who is unable to start or continue and any associated changes.'
In matches using VARs, this also applies to replay operators.

As special training and qualifications are needed to be a video match official (VMO)/replay operator, the following principles must be included in competition rules:

If no qualified replacement can be found for the VAR or replay operator,* the match must be played/continue without the use of VARs

If no qualified replacement can be found for the AVAR,* the match must be played/continue without the use of VARs unless, in exceptional circumstances, both teams agree in writing that the match may be played/continue with only the VAR and replay operator

**This does not apply where there is more than one AVAR/replay operator.*





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